



COVER
STORY

What sweet promises were uttered in the twilight of the phantasmagoric viceregal chambers? What threats and blackmail tactics were held out by the seasoned imperialist leaders of the nation of shopkeepers to make the relatively inexperienced nationalists swallow their own slogans of unity in diversity and join hands in public with their sworn enemies, who were known for their uncompromising hostility towards India's national aspirations? How was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the Iron Man of the Congress from Gujarat, softened to melting point? How was the great Mahatma, who declared that those who wanted partition could only walk over his dead body to their goal, silenced? This action really killed him long before he was shot at point-blank range by Nathuram Godse.

After all, were the Hindu fanatics right in shouting that the aging Congress leaders were eager to capture the throne before the predictable end of their lifespan at any cost? Were they frightened into submission by the cruel blood-letting sponsored by communalists on both sides? Were the nationalists scared by the communist prattle on the right of minorities to self-determination misused to serve communal ends? Why did the great Persian scholar Abul Kalam Azad withdraw into a shell and decide to con-

Only Gandhi, who had done

his best to avoid the horror of Partition, anticipated the troubles to follow and offered penance by fasting in a remote village of West Bengal.



fine his protest against national leadership to his testament, to be sealed and kept until their message lost all its punch with the passage of time? These questions remain unanswered to this day, and are probably unanswerable too. It is admitted that they are only matters of historical curiosity when all those involved have safely disappeared behind the dark curtain of time.

More mysterious is the fact that Hindu leaders like Jaswant Singh chose to keep their allegations against Nehru and praise of Jinnah secret all these years until those political bombs were defused by the impact of treacherous time. He could have used them with terrible effect earlier. Anybody who expects a political storm to follow this will have to be disappointed. What follows will only be a storm in the tea cup of the BJP causing the loss of membership



for the author in a party that is losing its credibility and popularity and moving fast on the slippery path of decline. Jinnah's jealousy of Nehru made him choose a suicidal course which he seems to have regretted at the fag end of his life. This new-born admiration for Jinnah can spell the doom of Jaswant's political career within Hindutva circles. Otherwise it is not capable of altering the existing notions about the role of Nehru or Jinnah in India's freedom struggle. In the absence of new significant revelations of evidence, the ripples of controversy are bound to subside soon without leaving any trace.

Now that the noise and dust of Partition has settled down after sixty years, it is possible to see events in clearer light, and judge without being swayed by sentiments and personal loyalties.